# Before You Break Ground:

## The Project Sponsor's Pre-Construction Governance Checklist in Africa

*What must be directed, structured and locked before your African construction project mobilises — and what it costs when it isn't.*

| 70% | 20–30% | Up to 20% |
|---|---|---|
| of construction project problems are locked in before ground is broken | cost variation exposure traced to incomplete pre-construction governance | total cost savings achievable when governance is installed at inception |

In African construction projects, the pre-construction phase is where the project is won or lost — before a single worker arrives on site. Design gaps, contractual weaknesses, procurement blind spots, and missing governance authority structures are not discovered during construction. They are created during pre-construction and surface during construction at a cost that is always higher than prevention. This checklist covers the governance areas that Proconix directs, structures, and locks in before any project we lead is mobilised.

**GOVERNANCE READINESS SCAN · Mark each area: ✓ Structured ■ Partially Done ✗ Not in Place**

### DOMAIN 1 — TECHNICAL & EXECUTION READINESS | P.Eng (Civil) Technical Governance Layer

#### AREA 1 — Design Coordination & Constructability

**Has the design been reviewed for constructability in the African context — accounting for local material availability, local contractor capability, and site-specific conditions — before contractor appointment?**

✓ ■ ✗

A design produced to international standards is not automatically buildable under African site conditions with locally available materials and labour. If this review has not been completed, the gap between design intent and site execution surfaces as variations, delays, and rework — during construction, when it is most expensive to resolve.

■ **Financial Signal: Unreviewed constructability = 20–30% variation exposure embedded before ground is broken.**

#### AREA 2 — Schedule & Critical Path Governance

**Has an independent critical path schedule been produced and validated — with milestones tied to actual procurement lead times, permit timelines, and contractor mobilisation capacity in Africa?**

✓ ■ ✗

A schedule built on assumption rather than ground-level data creates a false sense of control. In African construction environments, import lead times, customs clearance windows, and local contractor mobilisation timelines are project-specific realities that must be verified — not assumed — before the programme is locked and contractors are mobilised.

■ **Financial Signal: An unvalidated schedule typically produces 30–50% slippage by construction midpoint with no contractual recovery mechanism.**

### DOMAIN 2 — COMMERCIAL & CONTRACTUAL READINESS | MBA Business Acumen Governance Laye

#### AREA 3 — Scope Lock & Variation Protocol

**Is the project scope documented with sufficient precision that any deviation will be immediately identifiable — and is a formal variation approval protocol written into the contract before the first contractor is signed?**

✓ ■

Scope ambiguity is the single largest source of cost escalation in African construction projects. Without a precisely defined scope and a formal written change control protocol, every disagreement between design intent and site execution becomes a commercial negotiation — not a contractual right — with outcomes that consistently favour the contractor.

## DOMAIN 3 — PROCUREMENT & SUPPLY CHAIN READINESS | Africa On-Ground Execution Intelligence

### AREA 5 — Procurement Strategy & Import Risk

**Has a procurement strategy been established — covering locally sourced vs. imported materials, import duty provisions, currency exposure on USD/EUR purchases, customs clearance lead times, and supplier benchmarking — before contractor mobilisation?**

In African construction markets, procurement is where financial exposure accumulates silently. Import delays, unexpected duty classifications, currency movements, and supplier leverage in markets with limited competition are not exceptional events — they are normal. A procurement strategy established before mobilisation is a capital protection instrument. Established after, it is a reactive document.

■ **Financial Signal: Unstructured procurement in African projects = 8–15% cost inflation above initial estimates with no contractual recovery mechanism.**

✓ ■ ✗

### AREA 6 — Long-Lead Item Sequencing & Supply Chain Governance

**Have long-lead items — specialist equipment, imported fixtures, MEP systems — been identified, their procurement timelines mapped against the construction schedule, and governance assigned to a responsible party with clear authority?**

In Africa, long-lead item delays are the most common cause of critical path disruption. Equipment ordered late — or without governance oversight on specifications and factory inspection — creates site-stoppage conditions that are expensive, contractually complex, and reputationally damaging. This is particularly acute in hospitality projects with operator opening commitments.

■ **Financial Signal: Long-lead delays produce standing-time costs and LD exposure that frequently exceeds the governance cost that would have prevented them.**

✓ ■ ✗

## DOMAIN 4 — GOVERNANCE & AUTHORITY READINESS | Sponsor-Aligned Project Leadership

### AREA 7 — Sponsor Authority Matrix

**Is it documented — in writing — who has authority to approve variations, release payments, make scope decisions, and sign off on design changes, at which financial threshold, and who this authority defaults to when the primary decision-maker is unavailable?**

In African construction projects managed by sponsors who are frequently abroad or managing multiple priorities, decision-making gaps are a primary cause of contractor-driven delays. When authority is undefined, contractors and consultants fill the vacuum — not always in the sponsor's interest. Undefined authority structures consistently produce 8–16 hours per week of unnecessary escalation.

■ **Financial Signal: Undefined authority matrices create commercial decisions that should have been governed decisions — at a cost that compounds week by week.**

✓ ■ ✗

### AREA 8 — Governance Layer Appointment

**Has a sponsor-aligned construction project governance professional — with both technical construction credentials and Africa-specific execution experience — been appointed to direct, manage, and execute governance on your behalf before contractor mobilisation?**

This is the structural question that all seven areas above depend on. A governance layer installed at inception directs the design review, structures the contracts, establishes the procurement strategy, validates the schedule, and defines the authority matrix. It then manages execution throughout the full project lifecycle. Governance engaged after problems emerge is crisis management — always 3–5x more expensive than prevention.

■ **Financial Signal: Governance at inception vs. mid-crisis = 3–5x cost differential. Prevention is always cheaper than recovery.**

✓ ■ ✗

## DOMAIN 5 — REGULATORY & STATUTORY READINESS | Africa Compliance Governance

*Regulatory and statutory readiness in African construction projects includes, but is not limited to, the following areas. Proconix's governance role is to ensure these items are tracked, sequenced, and integrated into the project programme — so they do not become site-stoppage events during execution.*

| # | Compliance Area | Diagnostic Question | Mark |
|---|---|---|---|
| 9 | **Land Title & Ownership** | Has legal due diligence on land title, encumbrances, and boundary disputes been completed and certified before any construction commitment? | ✓ ■ ✗ |
| 10 | **Construction Permit & Building Approval** | Has the full construction permit been issued by the relevant local authority — not applied for, but actually issued — before contractor mobilisation? | ✓ ■ ✗ |
| 11 | **Investment Authority Compliance** | Has the required investment registration and approval been obtained from the relevant authority (e.g. ZIPA, TIC, ZIA) with all attached conditions documented | ✓ ■ ✗ |
| 12 | **Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA)** | Has a statutory EIA been completed, approved, and its conditions integrated into the construction programme and contractor obligations? | ✓ ■ ✗ |
| 13 | **HSE & Labour Compliance** | Are the project HSE plan and labour law obligations — including local content requirements where applicable — documented and ready for regulatory inspection | ✓ ■ ✗ |

**Any ✗ in Domain 5 is a project-stoppage risk — not a future concern. Regulatory non-compliance discovered after mobilisation in Africa produces costs that are always disproportionate to what compliance would have cost at inception.**

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### READINESS SCORE — Count your ✓ answers across all 13 areas

| | |
|---|---|
| 0 – 3 ✓ | Critical Exposure. This project is set up for financial loss before a single brick is laid. |
| 4 – 6 ✓ | High Risk. Mobilising now embeds problems that will cost more to resolve mid-construction than to prevent today. |
| 7 – 10 ✓ | Partially Protected. Unstructured areas will create pressure within 90 days of mobilisation — they will not self-resolve. |
| 11–13 ✓ | Strong Foundation. However: a ✓ on paper is not the same as a governance structure that holds under contractor pressure |

*Important: A score of 11–13 confirms the elements exist. It cannot confirm they are structured correctly for your specific project type, location, and contractor profile in Africa. The quality of what is in place — not just its presence — determines financial and technical outcomes.*

### WHAT THIS CHECKLIST CANNOT TELL YOU

This checklist identifies whether the thirteen foundational governance areas are in place before your project mobilises. It cannot assess whether your design has been reviewed by someone with hands-on African constructability experience, whether your contracts genuinely protect you under your specific project conditions and jurisdiction, whether your procurement strategy accounts for your specific supply chain realities in Africa, or whether your governance layer — if appointed — is structured to direct and execute on your behalf or merely to observe and report. Proconix does not provide governance observation. We Direct, Manage, and Execute construction project governance in Africa across all five domains — from inception through to successful handover.

## DM 'Pre-Ground' or 'Governance 2026'

Send a direct message on LinkedIn — receive a governance readiness conversation tailored to your specific project.

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*Directing, Managing & Executing Construction Project Governance in Africa*

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